

Techno-Skepticism and Childhood

Human development, social connection,
education, and AI

HUMANS ARE “ULTRASOCIAL”

“Humans aren’t just social, like dogs and chimpanzees, we are ultrasocial, like bees and ants.” – E. O. Wilson

LIKE BEES AND ANTS



Large-scale cooperation



Division of labor



Collective survival



One-for-all, all-for-one



Hive



HUMANS



Massive-scale cooperation



Division of labor



Collective thriving



One-for-all, all-for-one



Society built on shared culture



Our “hive” is not made of wax.
It is made of **shared culture** and **shared experiences**.



Our deep need for community and communion is **wired into our biology**.

“ Ultrasociality is our superpower.



We build civilizations



Solve complex problems



Create cultures, science, art & justice



Research Framework

Key Question:

How do digital technologies affect childhood development, attention, learning, and relationships?

THE PHONE-BASED CHILDHOOD

A rapid technological shift rewired where and how childhood happens.

BEFORE ~2007

CHILDHOOD OFFLINE

Limited connectivity.
Life happened in the real world.



In-person play



Face-to-face friendships



Local communities

~2007 – 2012

THE TRANSITION

Smartphones emerge.
Connectivity goes everywhere.



Always-on internet



Messaging & social apps



Screens become portable

2012 – TODAY

THE PHONE-BASED CHILDHOOD

Smartphones + social media
reshape daily life.



Social life moves online



Notifications & infinite scroll



24/7 access in their pocket

THE BIG SHIFT

Childhood moved
from the **real world**
to the **online world**.



More time online,
less time in person



Platforms designed to
capture attention



Social comparison
and pressure increase



Sleep, focus, and
well-being suffer



Key Takeaway:

The smartphone didn't just add to childhood—
it fundamentally changed where childhood happens.



Mechanisms of Social Bonding

Shared meals •
Laughter •
Movement • Physical
presence • Touch

These evolved
bonding mechanisms
are weakened online.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Childhood is a critical window for social and brain development.

What changes in childhood has lifelong consequences.

STRONG, REAL-WORLD CONNECTIONS

Builds skills for life.



VS.

WEAKER, DIGITAL CONNECTIONS

Carries hidden costs.



Shapes the Developing Brain

Early experiences wire neural pathways that influence emotions, behavior, and learning.



Affects Lifelong Outcomes

Social connection is a predictor of health, success, and happiness in adulthood.



Vulnerability Window

Puberty is a period of heightened sensitivity to social rewards and social threats.



Our Responsibility

Parents, educators, tech leaders, and policymakers shape the environment kids grow up in.



The bottom line:

Protecting human connection today
is an investment in a **healthier, more resilient** tomorrow.

